

SPI 387: Education Policy

Week 8 Precept

This Week: Teachers, Instruction, and Reform

- Green, Elizabeth, 2014. *Building a Better Teacher: How Teaching Works (And How to Teach It to Everyone)*. WW Norton & Company. Chapter 1.
- Mancenido, Zid. 2021. "How High Achievers Learn that They Should Not Become Teachers." *Harvard Educational Review* 91(4): 433-456.
- Valenzuela, Angela. 2005. "Subtractive Schooling, Caring Relations, and Social Capital in the Schooling Of US-Mexican Youth." *Beyond silenced voices: Class, race, and gender in United States schools*: 83-94.
- Turetsky, Kate M., Stacey Sinclair, Jordan G. Starck, and J. Nicole Shelton. 2021. "Beyond Students: How Teacher Psychology Shapes Educational Inequality." *Trends in Cognitive Sciences* 25(8): 697-709.

Green (2014)

- In a fifth-grade math class, Lampert balances content, timing, and classroom dynamics; using a wrong answer to reveal how students think and guide them toward understanding
- Effective teaching means unpacking student reasoning, not just correcting mistakes; it's about understanding *why* they're wrong before helping them get it right
- Good teaching involves being mindful of students' identities—making choices that avoid reinforcing stereotypes and promote inclusion
- Text rejects the idea of the “natural-born teacher” and argues that teaching is a learnable skill, built through practice, reflection, and strategic decision-making

Mancenido (2021)

- Peers, parents, and campus culture send messages—both openly and subtly—that teaching is unprestigious and a fallback option, suggesting that becoming a teacher means “settling”
- The teaching field’s reputation for low pay and little respect reinforces this view; students often hear stories about teachers being undervalued or treated poorly
- On elite campuses, there’s an unspoken expectation that top students will pursue high-status, high-paying careers like law, medicine, or engineering
- Mancenido argues that to attract strong students to teaching, we must change how the profession is valued—not just offer better pay, but challenge the cultural stigma around it

Valenzuela (2005)

- At Seguin High, schools subtract from Mexican American students' identities by discouraging their language and cultural expression instead of building on them
- Immigrant students often do better because they maintain stronger cultural ties and support networks, while U.S.-born students lose those connections over time.
- Teachers frequently misinterpret caring, expecting compliance and academic effort before showing genuine care or understanding
- Valenzuela argues for additive schooling: education that values students' culture, fosters authentic relationships, and strengthens community-based support

Turetsky et al. (2021)

- Educational inequality isn't just about resources; it's also shaped by teachers' beliefs, expectations, and biases toward different groups of students
- Implicit bias and low expectations often lead teachers to grade, call on, or encourage students differently based on race, class, or gender
- Three key mechanisms of inequality: disparate assessment, disparate interaction, and disparate impact
- Teachers who adopt a growth mindset and multicultural awareness help close achievement gaps and create fairer classrooms

Scenario

Ms. Smith is starting her first year as a third grade math teacher. Her classroom...

- Has a total of 20 students
- Is racially and socioeconomically diverse
- Has an equal number of boys and girls

She knows that in order to be a successful teacher, she will need to adopt some useful qualities/behaviors. **Write down 5 behaviors she should embody, using support from the week's readings, as well as from your own schooling experiences.**

Discussion Question #1

Mancenido interviews several students at elite institutions, all of whom once considered being teachers, but were, for some reason or other, led away from that path. As a student at an elite institution, did you relate to any of the accounts shared in the reading?

Discussion Question #2

What are some reasons people might find the teaching profession unappealing? What, if anything, could be done to make it more appealing?